

HIGH SCHOOLS

East Tech, Collinwood gain title game

By DICK ZUNT

PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

The cast is set for Friday's Senate Athletic League girls city championship basketball game at Cleveland South.

GIRLS BASKETBALL

East Tech, the No. 1 seed, will meet Collinwood, the No. 2 seed at 5:45 p.m. for all the marbles, taken home last year by East Tech.

East Tech wore its credentials well yesterday on its way to a 72-16 victory over fourth-seeded Glenville, and Collinwood, behind a sizzling third quarter by senior Katrina Leaks, defeated John F. Kennedy, 66-49, in semifinal games at East Tech.

East Tech, The Plain Dealer's No. 1-ranked team and the No. 10-

ranked Division I team in Ohio, started slowly but picked up steam in the opening game.

East Tech led, 14-0, at the end of the first quarter and increased its lead to 34-6 at halftime. The Lady Scarabs boosted their record to 18-1.

"We started slow," said East Tech's Barbara Turner, who led four double-figure scorers with 21. "We did not want to show too much since we have to prepare for the championship game."

Other double-figure scorers for East Tech were Danisha Garrison with 18 points, Khadijah Abdulhaq with 13 and Juvanna Rivers with 10.

"Our defense created the offense," said East Tech coach William Stovall. "(Glenville) coach Gretchen Taylor is a great coach,

but her girls do not have the ball-handling skills that my girls have. That put them at a great disadvantage."

Taylor said: "They're awesome; they are well-coached."

Glenville fell to 8-11.

The second game saw second-seeded Collinwood move out in front, 15-7, at the end of the first quarter before JFK asserted itself.

Behind a balanced attack, JFK outscored the Lady Railroaders, 17-12, in the second quarter.

A 3-point field goal by Kimberly Hill, who led her team with 15 points, cut the Collinwood lead to 25-24 with 1:49 remaining in the second quarter. Two free throws by Leaks with 1:07 left in the quarter gave Collinwood a 27-24 lead at intermission.

The score was tied at 28 and 30

early in the third quarter before the 5-6 Leaks took over.

She scored 19 straight points in the third quarter to push the Lady Railroaders into the lead. Only a layup by Tequisha Logan broke Leaks' scoring string. Collinwood led, 48-37, after three quarters.

"At halftime, coach [James Spurrier] told me to play my game," said Leaks, who led all scorers with 30. "That's what I did. I had to do what I had to do."

Crystal Lewis scored 11 points for Collinwood, but she picked up her third personal foul at 3:21 of the third quarter and had to go to the bench.

"They outplayed us, but our girls have had a heck of a season," said JFK coach Leonard Patterson.

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GIRLS BASKETBALL INSIDER

Coleman finds more to life than basketball

By EDDIE DWYER

PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

You won't see her name listed among the who's who of area players. After all, when you play for a team with a losing record, scouts don't exactly knock down your door.

But, as far as Maple Heights senior guard Amber Coleman is concerned, the future appears limitless.

Coleman, whose endless hustle and relentless defense have caught the attention of rival Lake Erie League coaches and players, possesses a resume that would open any door.

A three-year mainstay for the Lady Mustangs, Coleman carries a grade-point average of better than 4.00. She is president of the 'Lean Mean Marching Machine' marching band and is a member of the National Honor Society.

Honored last month with the Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. Award from the African-American Archives of the Western Reserve Historical Society, Coleman has been offered academic scholarships from Kent State, Thiel College and the University of Dayton. The King award was for her school and social work. Last year's female Army Reserve Scholar Athlete, she received a Congressional Honorable Mention from Congresswoman Stephanie Tubbs Jones for her work titled "An Artistic Discovery."

During the school's Veteran's Day assembly, Coleman shared a poem she composed, an inspirational work that accompanies the Vietnam Traveling Wall.

And, as though those skills weren't consuming enough, the dynamic point guard still finds time to get a triple-double on the basketball court (double figures in points, steals and assists), establish career assist records, earn all-conference and all-district honors in volleyball, and run track.

A role model in every sense, Coleman's triple-double, which was recognized in this forum last week, drew the attention of several Maple Heights fourth-graders.

Coleman's mother and a fourth-grade teacher, Jessica L. Coleman said her students were taping the article to their clothing and other items. The class has The Plain Dealer delivered every Monday, Wednesday and Friday as an informational resource, a source for creating class projects and for pleasure reading.

And, in a time when so many articles account for the despair surrounding adolescence, reading about a talented young woman like Amber Coleman is indeed a pleasure.

TOURNEY TIME — The Solon Division I sectional-district again will be one of the more

interesting and competitive in the area.

Barring a major upset, top-seeded East Tech, the defending district champion at Solon, will meet fourth-seeded Cleveland Heights in a district semifinal March 2 at 6:30 p.m. While Brecksville-Broadview Heights and Garfield Heights, seeded second and third, respectively, are expected to meet in the other semifinal on March 2 at 8 p.m., their roads to the district are much tougher.

Brecksville, last season's district runner-up at Solon, will face the winner of Bedford-Nordonia in a sectional final Feb. 26 at 7:30 p.m. The first game that night, scheduled for 6, will send Garfield Heights against the winner of Cleveland John F. Kennedy-Shaker Heights. The first round, or sectional openers, are scheduled for Feb. 23 at 6:30 and 8 p.m.

If Garfield Heights (15-3) ends up facing Shaker Heights (13-4), it will mark the second time this month that the two Lake Erie League programs collide. The Lady Bulldogs, a member of the LEL's Erie Division, and the Lady Raiders, who compete in the LEL's Lake Division, meet in a regular-season finale Feb. 16 in Shaker Heights' new Raider Dome.

A REAL STEAL — Garfield Heights senior center Karyn Woloszynek made her final home game a memorable one.

In helping the Lady Bulldogs rally to a 48-46 victory over Shaw and earn at least a share of the Erie Division title, Woloszynek came up with five steals and sealed the victory with a free throw in the final seconds. The five steals give her 88 on the season, tying the school mark she set last year.

An honors student, Woloszynek will further her education and basketball career on scholarship at Cleveland State.

ONE TO WATCH — Brecksville (16-1), ranked eighth in The Plain Dealer's Top 25 poll, will attempt to earn a share of the Pioneer Conference title when it plays host to seventh-ranked Berea (15-2) on Saturday night. The junior-varsity game will tip off at 6. Berea, which has dominated its PC competition, did just that to Brecksville last month, defeating the Bees, 79-53, in Berea.

AMONG THE BEST — Shaker Heights junior forward Tracy Jacobs, who has earned Plain Dealer Player of the Week honors each of her first three varsity seasons, totaled 54 points and 20 rebounds last week, including 21 points and 10 rebounds in an upset of Lake Division champion Elyria at Elyria.

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All square in MAC-8

Hurricanes tie Devils for top spot

By EDDIE DWYER

PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Defense, rebounding and pushing the ball up the floor.

Brooklyn's Danielle Mezzulo, Katie Palumbo and Jessica Latimer

GIRLS BASKETBALL

echoed those words as they described what was the Hurricanes' biggest victory of the regular season.

And their descriptions were accurate.

Brooklyn, controlling the boards, playing aggressive defense in the post and attacking on offense, defeated Independence, 56-50, last night in the MAC-8 girls basketball headliner in Brooklyn.

BROOKLYN 56
INDEPENDENCE 50

The Hurricanes, who are laden with underclassmen, including one of the area's more impressive freshman in Latimer, improved to 14-4 and moved into a tie for first place with Independence at 12-1. The Lady Devils, who got a game-high 30 points from senior forward Tiffany Smejkal, are 15-3 overall.

If Brooklyn wins at Beachwood on Friday and Independence is successful against Gilmour at home Friday, the teams will share the MAC-8 crown.

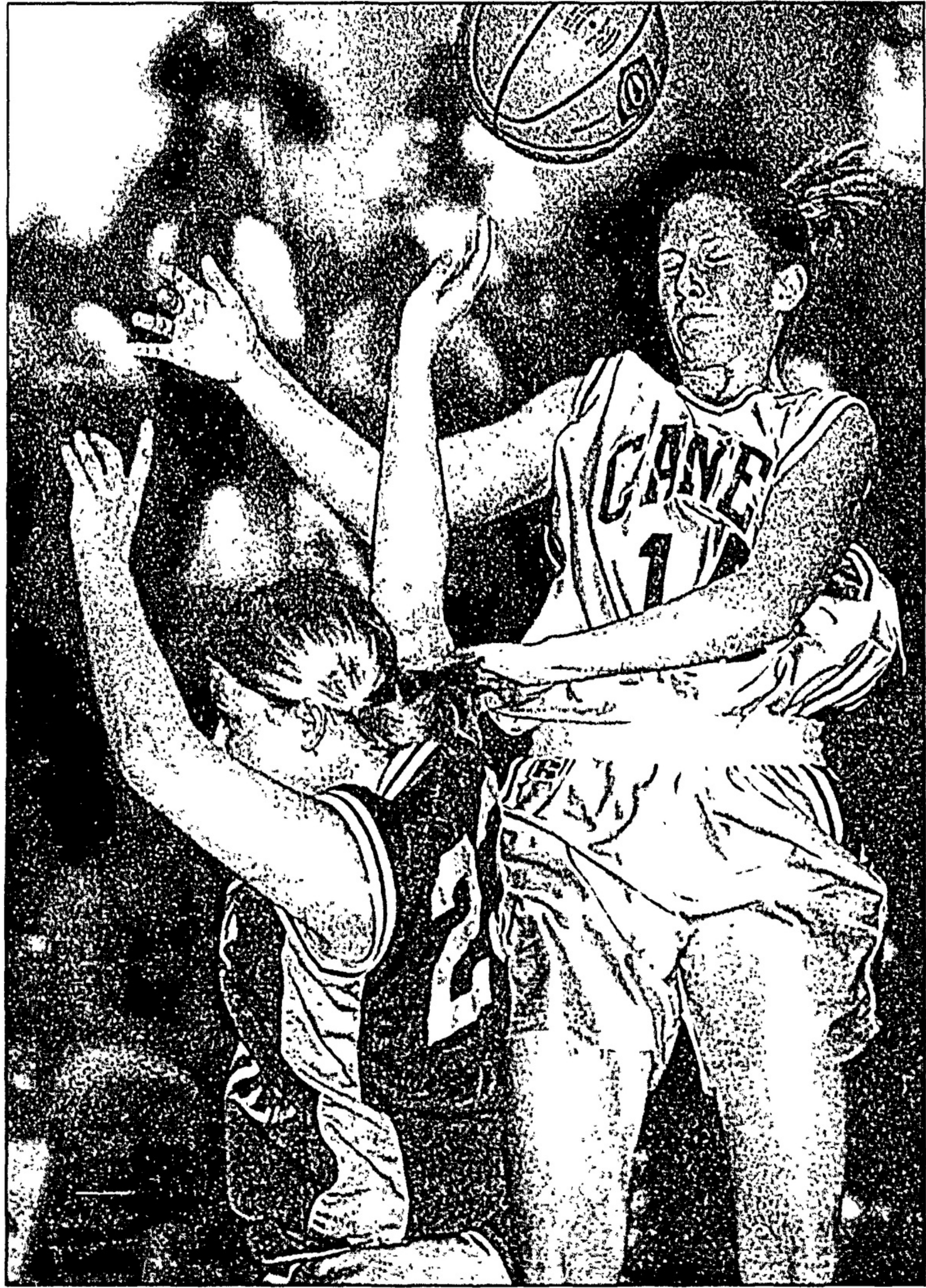
"They just killed us with about 17 offensive rebounds at their place," said Hurricanes coach Jim Verba, referring to a 55-38 loss at Independence on Jan. 5. "We spent the last two days in practice working on our post play."

"The last time, we played in front of them. But tonight, we played behind them and made them shoot over us."

With Latimer scoring down low, Brooklyn held a 10-7 lead after the first quarter and stretched its advantage to 19-9 on a turnaround jumper in the lane and a free throw by Latimer with 5:09 remaining in the first half. A 5-9 forward, Latimer led the Hurricanes with 20 points, 11 in the second half.

On the strength of a 3-pointer by freshman point guard Sarah Douglass and a buzzer-beating 15-footer by Mezzulo, Brooklyn led, 26-17, at halftime. The Hurricanes' balance offset an outstanding performance by Smejkal, who scored 14 points in the first 16 minutes, including all seven of the Lady Devils' first-quarter points.

"We didn't want to do that," said Mezzulo with a smile after she was told that Smejkal tied her



SCOTT SEAM / PLAIN DEALER PHOTOGRAPH

Dana Dempsey, right, and Independence's Carrie Stretar collide in the second quarter of Brooklyn's 56-50 girls basketball victory last night.

own school record with the 30 points. "But we did a good job of shutting down some of their other people, especially in the post."

Controlling the offensive glass and going strong to the basket, Brooklyn pushed its lead to 33-20 on a basket and a free throw by Latimer, a putback by Mezzulo and a driving one-hander by freshman guard Dana Dempsey.

But Smejkal, who played the entire 32 minutes, kept finding her second wind, and Independence, on the strength of a breakaway layup by junior forward

April Wood off an assist from Smejkal, closed to 43-37 entering the fourth quarter. Smejkal and Latimer each scored nine points in the third quarter.

Brooklyn, which has an accumulative team grade-point average of more than 3.0, led, 47-37, after Palumbo hit a jumper from the top of the key with 6:25 left. A three-point play and a driving layup by Smejkal brought the Lady Devils to within 55-50 with 1:53 to go, but the Hurricanes sealed the victory behind the defense of Mezzulo, who had 16

points, a clutch defensive rebound by Latimer and a free throw by Douglass.

"It was an exceptional performance," said Independence coach Eric Magyar of Smejkal's effort. "But they just killed us on the boards. Latimer came out and played with a lot of poise for a freshman. She's only going to get stronger. There's no shame in sharing the conference championship with a team like Brooklyn."

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Olmsted Falls holds off Strongsville in overtime

FROM PLAIN DEALER

Strongsville fought back from a 17-point deficit, but Olmsted Falls scored 16 points in overtime to win, 85-78, in a nonleague boys basketball game last night.

ROUNDUP

Mike Gansey scored 29 points to lead Falls (14-2). Manzie Williams had 18 points.

Strongsville (9-8) scored 11 straight points early in the fourth quarter. Bob Bossman scored 17 points for the Mustangs.

Barberton 52, Brush 48 — The Magics shook off some road jitters and sloppy play in the first half to edge the Arcs in a Western Reserve Conference interdivisional game.

The Magics, ranked No. 9 in The Plain Dealer Top 25 Poll, found themselves down, 25-15, at halftime thanks to 19 of their 23 turnovers. They came back to outscore the Arcs, 37-23, in the second half.

Senior Chad Hazard led Barberton's late charge by scoring

Lakewood, Euclid advance

FROM PLAIN DEALER

Dave Nieves had a hat trick as Lakewood defeated Chagrin Falls, 5-2, last night in quarter-final action of hockey's Baron Cup II tournament at Brooklyn.

Nieves opened the scoring just over a minute into the game off assists from

Andy Senkovich and James Frazier.

Mike Hood scored twice to give Chagrin Falls a 2-1 lead early in the second period. But Frazier

eight of his 14 points in the fourth quarter.

Orange 87, Kirtland 43 — The Lions outscored the Hornets, 11-1, in the second quarter en route to victory in Chagrin Valley Conference interdivisional play.

scored two minutes later, and Nieves answered with his second and third goals. Frazier assisted on both, with Senkovich and Chris Maline also picking up assists.

Euclid 4, Brooklyn 1 — The Panthers scored four straight goals after falling behind in last night's second game. Nick Verch, Josh Nagle and Chris Gates scored in the first period for the winners. Ed Ostrander scored an empty-netter in the third period.

Nick Badza scored for Brooklyn.

Orange, ranked No. 13, was led by senior guards Alex Gray and Marc Comer, each with 10 points. C.J. Trivisonno led Kirtland with 20 points.

Elyria Catholic 70, Holy Name 64 — The Panthers bat-

tled back from a 30-26 halftime deficit en route to a North Coast League upset over the No. 19-ranked Green Wave.

Jason Tagiolo had 18 points for Elyria Catholic, and Ross Rybarezyk and Jason Kaminski each scored 13 points.

Trinity 62, Lake Catholic 59 — Senior Billy Moore scored 28 points in leading the Trojans to a North Coast League victory.

Avon Lake 61, Brunswick 54 — Brian Ingleright had a game-high 17 points, including two crucial 3-pointers in the fourth quarter, to lead the No. 22-ranked Shoremen to a nonleague victory.

Warrensville Hts. 90, Southview 81 — No. 25 Southview pulled to within five points in the final quarter but couldn't pull it out against the No. 5-ranked Tigers.

Julius Johnson led Warrensville with 34 points. Scott Remaklus clicked on seven 3-pointers en route to 30 points for Southview.

THE PLAIN DEALER
PLAYERS OF THE WEEK

Christina Estrick

School: Euclid
Sport: Basketball Class: Senior
Age: 17 Ht: 5-9 Wt: 138

Last week: Scored 38 and 31 points as Lady Panthers lost to Cleveland Heights and defeated Willoughby South; totaled 20 rebounds, six steals and four 3-pointers and was 11-of-12 from free-throw line.

Season: Averages 24.9 points, 11.3 rebounds and four steals.

Personal: Is among state's premier high jumpers and long jumpers in track and field; also enjoys bowling; favorite player is Shonda Robinson.



Tamika Dixon

School: Cleveland Heights
Sport: Basketball Class: Senior
Age: 17 Ht: 5-9 Wt: 140

Last week: Led victories over Shaker Heights, Magnificat and Euclid by totaling 44 points, 35 rebounds, 11 assists and four blocks; was 4-of-6 on 3-pointers against Euclid and played solid defense against Magnificat.

Season: Averages 16 points, 12 rebounds, five steals and three as-

sists.

Personal: Also competes in volleyball and track; enjoys spending time with family, watching "The Simpsons" and "Hill from the Streets" and listening to JG and Aaliyah; favorite players are Grant Hill, Katrina Carr and Meghan Goode.